I believed—and I intended to make it a theme of my campaign—that America's greatest years were ahead of it, that we had to look at the things that had made it the greatest, richest, and most progressive country on earth in the first place, decide what had gone wrong, and then put it back on course.

In September, Nancy and I rented a lovely home in the Virginia hunt country an hour or so from Washington called Wexford, once owned by Jacqueline Onassis, to serve as our base of operations while I stumped the country in the final weeks of the campaign.

On those rare days when we weren't on the campaign trail, I was able to ride across the lovely green hills and mentally sort out the problems we faced at the time.

Obviously, no one could take the challenge of defeating an incumbent president lightly. Although public opinion polls indicated Americans were fed up with the leadership in the White House, by then I had had enough experience in politics to realize that no one, least of all the candidate, should take anything for granted.

I tried to focus the campaign on the things that had gone wrong in America during the previous four years, especially regarding the economy, and to present my vision of how, working together, we as a people could get our country back on track again and advance it toward the fulfillment of its destiny.

Carter took a low road of personal attacks on my character. Because I said I believed states should be allowed to regain the rights and powers granted to them in the Constitution, he implied I was a racist pandering to Southern voters; because I opposed Senate ratification of the SALT II treaty in the belief it had serious weaknesses that would leave the Soviets with a dangerous preponderance of nuclear weapons—I wanted true arms *reduction*—Carter